PADHAKU
Footprints without Feet · Class 10 English



CHAPTER 9

The Book That Saved the Earth

NCERT Exercise Solutions

Scene 1 · Read and Find Out 2 Q

Scene 2 · Read and Find Out 1 Q

Think about it 4 Q

Talk about it 2 Q

✨ Try each question yourself first, then check the answer. 💡 answers are samples: write your own.

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⭐ Scene 1 · Read and Find Out

1 **Why was the twentieth century called the 'Era of the Book'?**

✔ ANSWER

The twentieth century was called the **'Era of the Book'** because there were books about everything, "from ant eaters to Zulus". Books taught people how to, when to, where to and why to do things. They illustrated, educated, punctuated and even decorated.

2 **Who tried to invade the earth in the twenty-first century?**

✔ ANSWER

The **Martians** from the planet Mars, led by the Great and Mighty Think-Tank, tried to invade the Earth in **2040** (the twenty-first century). The invasion never really happened, because a single book stopped it.

⭐ Scene 2 · Read and Find Out

1 **What guesses are made by Think-Tank about the books found on earth?**

✔ ANSWER

Think-Tank makes several foolish guesses:

- First he says the library is a **refreshment stand** and the books are **sandwiches**, the main food of Earthlings, and orders the crew to eat one.
- When Noodle says Earthlings used them for communication, he calls them **communication sandwiches** and orders the crew to **listen** to them.
- Then he says they are for **eye communication**, and that the lines and dots in them are a **code** which must be broken.

🤔 Think about it

1 **Noodle avoids offending Think-Tank but at the same time he corrects his mistakes. How does he manage to do that?**

✔ ANSWER

Noodle is clever and polite. He never says directly that Think-Tank is wrong. He addresses him with flattering titles like “your Brilliance” and “your Cleverness” and presents his correction as a humble, unimportant thought, e.g. “an insignificant bit of data floated into my mind” or “a cloudy piece of information is twirling around in my head”.

For example, he gently tells him that Earthlings did not eat the “sandwiches” but used them for communication, and that they opened and watched them instead of listening. Think-Tank then accepts the idea as his own (“That was my next point”), so his pride is not hurt and the mistake is corrected.

2 **If you were in Noodle’s place, how would you handle Think-Tank’s mistakes?**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

If I were in Noodle’s place, I would also be polite and respectful, because Think-Tank is proud and short-tempered. I would not insult him in front of others. I would give him the correct information gently, as a suggestion, and with facts or examples (like the surveyor films), so that he could see the truth himself.

At the same time, when his mistakes could cause serious harm, like a wrong decision about an invasion, I would speak more firmly and clearly, because hiding the truth to please a leader can be dangerous.

3 **Do you think books are being replaced by the electronic media? Can we do away with books altogether?**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

It is true that electronic media such as the internet, e-books, mobile apps and videos are becoming very popular. Information is quick to find, easy to carry and often free. Many people now read on phones and tablets instead of printed books.

But we cannot do away with books altogether.

- Books do not need electricity, internet or a device, so they reach everyone.
- Reading a printed book is easier on the eyes and helps concentration.
- Books are permanent records of knowledge and culture.
- Many people still love the feel and joy of a real book.

So electronic media can support books, but cannot fully replace them.

4 **Why are books referred to as a man's best companion? Which is your favourite book and why? Write a paragraph about that book.**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

Books are called a man's best companion because they are always with us and never let us down. They give us knowledge, guide us, entertain us, comfort us in loneliness and ask for nothing in return. Through books we can travel the world and meet great minds of the past.

My favourite book – *The Story of My Experiments with Truth*

My favourite book is *The Story of My Experiments with Truth*, the autobiography of Mahatma Gandhi. In simple language, Gandhiji tells the story of his life, from his childhood in Porbandar and his student days in London to his struggle against injustice in South Africa and India. What I like most is his honesty: he openly writes about his own mistakes and how he learnt from them. The book teaches truth, non-violence, simple living and self-discipline. It shows that an ordinary person can become great through hard work and strong values. Whenever I feel confused, this book gives me courage and direction. That is why it is my favourite book.

⭐ Talk about it

1 **In what ways does Think-Tank misinterpret innocent nursery rhymes as threats to the Martians? Can you think of any incidents where you misinterpreted a word or an action? How did you resolve the misunderstanding?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Think-Tank takes the rhymes literally:

- **“Mistress Mary, quite contrary”**: from “cockle shells and silver bells” growing in a garden, he thinks Earthlings can combine agriculture and mining and grow rare metals like silver, and even high explosives.
- **“Hey diddle diddle”**: from the cow jumping over the moon and the laughing dog, he thinks Earthlings have taught their animals music and space techniques, and may launch an attack of millions of cows.
- **“Humpty Dumpty”**: he thinks the egg-shaped Humpty Dumpty is a picture of himself, and “had a great fall” means Earthlings plan to capture him and Mars Central Control. In fear he cancels the invasion and orders all Martians to leave Mars.

My experience (sample): Once my friend did not answer my greeting at school. I thought she was angry with me and I stopped talking to her. Later I asked her calmly, and she told me she had not seen me because she was worried about her sick mother. I said sorry and we became friends again. I learnt that we should ask before we judge.

2 **The aliens in this play speak English. Do you think this is their language? What could be the language of the aliens?**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

No, English is probably not the aliens' own language. The Martians could not even recognise books or read the "code" of letters, so they could not really know English. The writer makes them speak English only so that the audience can understand the play.

The aliens' real language could be very different from ours, for example a language of sounds, beeps and electronic signals, signs and gestures, or even thought-waves (telepathy), since Think-Tank is shown with a huge "balloon brain".

🎉 **Chapter 9 done! Revise the answers once more tomorrow.**